OpticOS: design specification

Version 0.13, 13 November 2026. The design decisions in §12 were agreed the same day. v0.3 rebalanced the §8.2 budget after phase 3. v0.4 replaced the full-screen editor with a Sinclair-style line editor (§6.5, §6.6, decision 7) and rebalanced the budget again. v0.5 brought the document in line with the ROM as built through phase 4. **v0.6** (phase 5a) records INPUT, DATA/READ/RESTORE and the tape commands as built, drops ASN/ACS, and re-projects the budget (§8.2). **v0.7** (phase 5b) records Nathan's cuts as decisions 8–11 (§12), the squeezes, and graphics, colours, BEEP, the string and machine functions and SWAP as built, and adds the start-up chime (§6.7). **v0.8** (phase 5c) records the last cuts as decision 13 (array parameters by reference, `CALL` register arguments, `CAT`, the OpticBASIC `SCREEN$` tape forms, `JOY`), builds CASE, EXIT, `ERROR n, msg$`, CLEAR, FREE, KEY and the PROC-name forms of RUN, RESTORE and SAVE … AUTO, and completes the feature list within the 256-byte margin (§8.2). **v0.9** removes the last UDG mentions (§4.7, §5.4, §6.1, §9), records `TAB(c)` as built, lengthens the boot banner to `OpticOS (c) 2026 Optica Technology Design`, records the measured nesting limits (§4.8), corrects §6.1 (codes 128–255 print as `?`; no block graphics) and points to the user manual (`docs/manual`). **v0.10** fixes PROG (`DPEEK 23635` now gives the program start, 24048), makes `ERROR n` without a message report `Error n`, enlarges the stacks below RAMTOP on 48K machines (decision 15), and completes the company name, Optica Technology Design. **v0.11** halves the 48K stacks (decision 15) and adds the example tape (`examples/`). **v0.12** (after the v1.0 release) makes the tape routines safe under emulators that trap them (§3.1). **v0.13** makes colour 8 (transparent) work for PLOT and DRAW as well as PRINT (§6.4), adds error 21, "Keyword as name", for a DEF whose name is a keyword (§7.2), and adds `flag` to the example tape. Project, ROM and future repo name: **OpticOS**. Boot banner: `OpticOS (c) 2026 Optica Technology Design`.

This document covers design and planning only. The Z80 snippets in it are there to show technique. They are not the implementation.

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1. Goals and non-goals

Goals

1. **A drop-in 16,384-byte ROM image** for the 48K (and 16K) Spectrum that boots on real hardware, in Fuse and in our headless rig.
2. **OpticBASIC, a modern structured BASIC with no line numbers.** It has named procedures and functions with parameters and `LOCAL`, block `IF/ELSEIF/ELSE/ENDIF`, `WHILE`, `REPEAT`, `FOR`, `CASE`, labels in place of line-number `GOTO`, and `TRY/CATCH` error handling.
3. **64-column text as the default** (a condensed 4-pixel font in the spirit of Tasword Two) for PRINT and the editor. (A `MODE 32` switch was dropped in v0.7, decision 8.)
4. **A Sinclair-style line editor** (v0.4: a full-screen editor was dropped to save ROM). A movable current-line marker, EDIT to change a line, AUTO to type new ones. You type keywords letter by letter and a tokeniser converts them. There is no single-key keyword entry.
5. **Tape compatibility.** OpticOS uses the standard ROM tape encoding (pilot, sync, bit timings, flag and parity bytes, the 17-byte header layout), so ordinary TAP and TZX files load and OpticOS saves load on other tools.
6. **Machine-code compatibility where it is cheap.** RST vectors, IM 1 at `$0038`, NMI at `$0066`, LD-BYTES at `$0556`, SA-BYTES at `$04C2`, BEEPER at `$03B5` and a handful of others keep their addresses and register contracts.
7. **Speed.** The target is at least 3× Sinclair BASIC on integer loops, using a 16-bit integer fast path and pre-resolved control flow.
8. **Clean room.** OpticOS contains no Sinclair, Amstrad or Tasword code or artwork (see §1.3).

Non-goals

- Running existing Sinclair BASIC programs. The exception is the small **legacy loader** subset that tape loaders use (§3.4).
- Emulating the RST `$28` calculator byte-code interface.
- 128K paging, AY sound, the ZX Printer, Interface 1 and Microdrive. The `$0008` hook stays, so a later shadow ROM could still page in.
- An inline assembler like BBC BASIC's. It is too expensive in 16K. `CALL` and `USR` cover machine code.
- `MERGE`, `DATA` arrays on tape, `DEF FN` in the Sinclair style, `RENUM` and line-numbering `AUTO`. None of these make sense without line numbers. (OpticOS reuses the word `AUTO` for its line-entry mode, §6.5.)

1.3 Clean-room rules

- Nathan's `48.rom` (in `/workspace/ultimate/roms/`) is a **behavioural reference only**. We may run it in an emulator to measure register contracts, timings and outputs at the entry points we keep. We do not disassemble it into OpticOS source, and we do not paste its bytes or routines.
- The ROM image, the Ultimate snapshots and the scans are **never committed or published**. `roms/` stays in `.gitignore`, as in the Mire Mare repo.
- Public facts are fair to use: the tape signal format, the header layout, system-variable addresses, token numbers and published entry-point contracts.
- A `similarity_check.py` gate fails the build if `opticos.rom` shares any run of 12 or more identical bytes with `48.rom`. Font areas and runs of filler bytes are excluded from the check.
- **The font is original artwork.** Tasword Two (Tasman Software, 1983) inspired the idea of a 64-column font. We draw our own glyphs on a 3×6 grid, in an ASCII-art source file, without consulting Tasword's or Sinclair's bitmaps.

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2. Hardware compatibility

Item	Behaviour OpticOS relies on
CPU	Z80A at 3.5 MHz. 69,888 T-states per frame on the 48K. Contended memory at `$4000`–`$7FFF`.
ULA port `$FE` (any even port)	Writing sets the border (bits 0–2), MIC (bit 3) and EAR/beeper (bit 4). Reading gives keyboard half-rows (high byte selects the row, bits 0–4 active low) and EAR in (bit 6).
Keyboard matrix	8 half-rows × 5 keys. Row-select bytes are `$FE`, `$FD`, `$FB`, `$F7`, `$EF`, `$DF`, `$BF`, `$7F` (CAPS–V, A–G, Q–T, 1–5, 0–6, P–Y, ENTER–H, SPACE–B).
Kempston	Port `$1F`, active high: bit 0 right, 1 left, 2 down, 3 up, 4 fire. Read with `IN 31` (the `JOY` function was dropped in v0.8, decision 13). It is never auto-detected, because a floating bus reads `$FF`.
IM 1	Set at boot. The 50 Hz frame interrupt arrives at `$0038`.
NMI	`$0066`. If `NMIADD` (`$5CB0`) is non-zero, jump to it. Otherwise `RETN`.
Screen and graphics	`CLS`, `PRINT` / `?` with `;` `,` `'` `AT` `TAB`, `INK`, `PAPER`, `FLASH`, `BRIGHT`, `INVERSE`, `OVER` (as statements and inside PRINT, where INK, PAPER, FLASH and BRIGHT last until the statement ends; INVERSE and OVER stay set), `BORDER`, `INPUT`, `PLOT x,y`, `DRAW dx,dy`, `DRAW TO x,y` (256×192, origin bottom left; OVER flips and INVERSE clears pixels; each plotted cell takes the current colours)
RAM size	The boot memory test finds 16K (`P_RAMT=$7FFF`) or 48K (`$FFFF`).

Interrupt routine (`$0038`)

The routine does not use IY. It addresses the system variables directly. A game that repurposes IY and leaves IM 1 running crashes the Sinclair ROM, but it survives OpticOS. On each interrupt the routine:

1. Pushes AF, BC, DE and HL.
2. Increments the 24-bit `FRAMES` counter (`$5C78`).
3. Scans the keyboard into `KSTATE`-style debounce slots. It writes `LAST_K` (`$5C08`) and sets bit 5 of `FLAGS` (`$5C3B`), with `REPDEL` and `REPPER` auto-repeat.
4. (The input-line cursor blinks every 16 frames, timed from FRAMES by the console.)
5. Pops the registers, then `EI` and `RET`.

The budget is about 1,000 T-states on a typical frame and no more than 1,600.

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3. Compatibility policy

3.1 Tape format (kept exactly)

Element	Value
Pilot	2168 T per half-pulse. 8063 pulses for a header (flag `$00`), 3223 for data (`$FF`).
Sync	667 T, then 735 T.
Bits	0 = two 855 T half-pulses. 1 = two 1710 T half-pulses. MSB first.
Block	Flag byte, then data, then an XOR parity byte.
Header	17 bytes: type (0 program, 1 number array, 2 char array, 3 code), 10-char name, length, param 1, param 2.

OpticOS programs are saved as **type 0** headers, so tape catalogues still say "Program:". The data block begins with the 4-byte signature `"OB" $01 $00`. On LOAD, a type-0 block without this signature is a Sinclair BASIC program and is handed to the legacy loader (§3.4).

Tape traps (v0.12). Emulators that load `.tap` files instantly, or save them quickly, do it by trapping the ROM's tape routines at fixed addresses and returning through fixed points, without playing any signal. OpticOS keeps that layout so a trap either works or cannot misfire. The addresses come from Fuse's public source (`tape.c`, `z80/opcodes_base.c`) and the documented entry convention (IX = start, DE = length, A = flag, carry set = LOAD), not from the Sinclair code:

Address	OpticOS has	Used by
$04C2	SA-BYTES entry; the exit handler $053F is pushed first	save traps at the entry
$04D0	`EX AF,AF'` with A = flag and IX, DE as on entry	Fuse's save trap, which resumes at $053E
$053E	`RET` (pops the exit handler)	return point of save traps
$053F	`tape_ret`, the common exit: border, EI, BREAK check; safe to run twice	traps that return into SA/LD-RET
$0556	LD-BYTES entry; DI, `EX AF,AF'`, then pushes $053F	load traps at the entry
$0562	an instruction boundary, with the exit handler pushed and A' / F' set	Spectranet-style load traps
$056B	`RET NZ` reached with Z set, so never taken	Fuse's load trap, which resumes at $05E2
$05E2	`RET` (pops the exit handler)	return point of load traps

The legacy loader and OpticBASIC's LOAD read a header with one 17-byte call and a data block with one call of the header's length, as a trap expects. The tape signature `OB` $01 $00 lies at $0605 and the error-message table over $0767–$0808, so no OpticOS code is fetched where traps on the Sinclair ROM's higher-level tape entry points (the SAVE/LOAD command and header and block loading) would sit; LOAD reaches nothing at a published tape entry point before $0556. `tools/check_layout.py` checks the bytes, and `tools/rig/test_traps.py` loads and saves through emulated Fuse, entry and

Spectranet traps. v1.0 lacked this layout and crashed on The Spectrum (Retro Games, 2024) when loading a `.tap`.

3.2 Fixed entry points

Each one is either the real routine or a 3-byte `JP` stub at the original address. Its register contract is documented and tested.

Address	Name	Contract kept	Why	Cost
`$0000`	RESET	Cold start	Universal	in init
`$0008`	ERROR (RST 8)	Next byte is the error code	Some games and Interface 1	0
`$0010`	PRINT-A (RST 16)	Print A to the current channel	Very common in loaders and type-in code	0
`$0018`/`$0020`	GET/NEXT-CHAR	OpticOS's own interpreter fetch. Not guaranteed.	Vector slots	0
`$0028`	RST 40	**Not** the Sinclair calculator: since v0.8 it enters OpticOS's own maths byte-code (`fu_run`, docs/maths.md), so the 37 calls to it are one byte each. Sinclair calculator code cannot run on OpticOS either way.		0
`$0030`	RST 48	Workspace allocate (OpticOS's own)		0
`$0038`	IM 1 ISR	FRAMES and keyboard	Universal	in ISR
`$0066`	NMI	As §2 (the Sinclair bug is fixed)		4
`$03B5`	BEEPER	DE = cycles, HL = period, as documented	Many games use it for sound	stub
`$04C2`	SA-BYTES	IX = start, DE = length, A = flag	Savers and utilities	real routine
`$0556`	LD-BYTES	IX, DE, A = flag, carry set = load, carry clear = verify. Returns carry set on success.	**Most important.** Called by countless loaders.	real routine
`$05E3`/`$05E7`	LD-EDGE-2/1	B = timing counter in and out, carry clear = BREAK or time-out	Used by many custom and turbo loaders	real routine
`$096F`	`RET` byte	Makes the `POKE 23739,111` "hide Bytes: names" trick harmless	Seen in both Mire Mare and Bounce Ball loaders	1
`$0D6B`	CLS	Clear the screen with ATTR_P	Cheap and common	stub
`$0DAF`	CL-ALL	Same as CLS, and resets the print position	Cheap	stub
`$1601`	CHAN-OPEN	A = stream (−3..15)	RST 16 users	stub
`$203C`	PR-STRING	DE = address, BC = length	Common	stub
`$22AA`	PIXEL-ADD	B = y, C = x, gives HL = address, A = bit	Some games	stub
`$2D2B`/`$2DA2`	STACK-BC / FP-TO-BC	Not provided. The calculator stack is not emulated (§12).		0

The LD-EDGE timing is matched by black-box measurement: we feed pulses of known length and compare the returned B with the reference ROM in the rig. We do not read its code. The per-iteration loop time and the starting B values in LD-BYTES must match closely, so that turbo loaders which call `$05E7` with their own thresholds still work.

3.3 What breaks

Breaks	Impact	Mitigation
Existing Sinclair BASIC programs	Type-ins and BASIC games	None. The legacy loader runs only the loader subset.
Deep ROM calls (the calculator, `$0C0A` PO-MSG, `$1C82`-type syntax routines, mid-routine jumps)	A minority of games, and many utilities	Stubs for the top dozen (above). The rest are documented as unsupported.
RST `$28` calculator byte-code	A few games and demos	Raise an error instead of crashing
Sinclair 8×8 font at `$3D00`	Games that print with the ROM font, or set `CHARS=$3C00` and draw their own text	Accepted: it breaks. `MODE 32` uses pixel-doubled glyphs. There is no 8×8 font at `$3D00` for now; it may be revisited in Phase 5 if the margin allows (§12).
ROM checksums, or using ROM bytes as random data or sound	Copy protection and rare effects	None (different but harmless)
Sinclair's 32-column print layout	Loaders that `PRINT AT` assuming 32 columns, through the legacy shim	As built, the legacy shim prints at 64 columns and doubles the `PRINT AT` column, so a 32-column layout keeps its shape at half width (no 32-column print path is needed)
ZX Printer (`LPRINT`/`COPY`)	Negligible	Dropped

3.4 Legacy loader shim

Almost every commercial tape starts with a short BASIC loader. Both of our own test tapes do. Here are the Bounce Ball and Mire Mare loaders, decoded from the TAPs:

```
10 BORDER 0: CLEAR 32767: LOAD ""CODE : RANDOMIZE USR 32768          (Bounce Ball)
10 BORDER 0: PAPER 0: INK 0: CLEAR 24575: LOAD ""SCREEN$ :
   POKE 23739,111: LOAD ""CODE : RANDOMIZE USR 24576                 (Mire Mare)
```

The shim is a very small interpreter for Sinclair-tokenised programs. It loads the program at `$5CCB`, as the original does, because loaders often embed machine code at fixed addresses or `PEEK 23635`. It then interprets only these:

- `BORDER`, `PAPER`, `INK`, `BRIGHT`, `CLS`, `CLEAR n`, `POKE`, `RANDOMIZE USR`, `LOAD "" [CODE|SCREEN$] [a[,b]]`, `PRINT` with literals and `AT`, `REM`, `GO TO`, `RUN` and `:`
- Expressions using `USR`, `PEEK`, `+ - *`, `VAL "…"` and numbers. Numbers are taken from the hidden 5-byte form after each literal (the `$0E` marker), so no ASCII number parsing is needed.

Anything else stops with "Legacy BASIC: unsupported statement". The cost is about 650 bytes. Sinclair's token numbers for these keywords are a published interface, so recognising them is fine.

3.5 Policy (agreed)

Keep the tape format and the entry-point table above, put a `RET` at `$096F`, and include the legacy shim. Do not emulate RST `$28` or the calculator stack. There is no 8×8 ROM font for now; it may be revisited in Phase 5 if the margin allows (§12).

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4. Language definition (OpticBASIC)

4.1 Lexical rules

- **Keywords** are case-insensitive. LIST shows them in upper case. Identifiers are case-insensitive and folded to lower case.

- **Identifiers** start with a letter, followed by letters, digits or _. Up to 32 characters, all significant. The suffix `%` means a 16-bit integer and `$` means a string. With no suffix, the variable is a number held as a 5-byte float with the small-integer form.
- **Literals**: `123`, `1.5E-3`, hex `$C000`, binary `%10110001`, and strings in double quotes. Write a quote inside a string as `""`.
- **Comments** start with `REM` or `'` and run to the end of the line.
- **Statements** are one per line. `:` is allowed as a separator but is not needed.
- **Static integers** `A%`–`Z%` live at fixed RAM addresses, with no lookup, BBC-style. They are the fastest variables.

4.2 Data types

Type	Storage	Range or notes
Integer `x%`	2 bytes	−32768..32767. Overflow raises error 6.
Number `x`	5 bytes	Sinclair-layout float: exponent byte plus a 4-byte mantissa, about 9.5 significant digits, ±1.7E38. Integral values in −65535..65535 use the **small-integer form** `00 sign lo hi 00`, and the arithmetic fast path works on that form directly.
String `s$`	3-byte descriptor (length, pointer) plus heap bytes	0–255 characters
Arrays	`DIM a(9)`, `b%(3,3)`, `n$(20)`	Up to 3 dimensions, base 0, so `DIM a(9)` gives 10 elements. Each string array element is its own heap string.
Boolean	Integer	TRUE = −1, FALSE = 0. `AND`, `OR` and `XOR` are bitwise on integers.

4.3 Operator precedence (highest first)

Level	Operators	Associativity
1	`( )`, function calls, array subscripts	
2	`^`	right
3	unary `-`, unary `+`, `NOT`	right
4	`* / DIV MOD`	left
5	`+ -` (+ also joins strings)	left
6	`<< >>` (integer shifts)	left
7	`= <> < > <= >=`	left (non-chaining)
8	`AND`	left
9	`OR XOR`	left

`/` always returns a float. `DIV` is integer division.

4.4 Statements

Structure and procedures

```
DEF PROC name[(p1, p2$, p3%)]  … ENDPROC
DEF FN name[(params)]          … RETURN expr … ENDFN
DEF FN name(params) = expr                ' one-line form
LOCAL v, w$, k%, arr()                    ' first lines of a PROC or FN only
name [args]   or   name(args)             ' call a PROC (bare name)
' (LABEL / GOTO dropped in v0.7, decision 9: use PROCs; there is no GOSUB)
END   STOP   REM   '
```

Parameters are passed by value. (Passing arrays by reference with `a()` was dropped in v0.8, decision 13; arrays are global, so a PROC can use one by name.) Scoping is **dynamic, BBC-style**: `LOCAL` and

parameters save the old value on the control stack and restore it at ENDPROC, ENDFN or error unwind. Recursion is supported.

Control flow

```
IF c THEN stmt [ELSE stmt]                ' one-line form
IF c                                      ' block form (nothing after the condition)
  …
ELSEIF c
  …
ELSE
  …
ENDIF
WHILE c … WEND
REPEAT … UNTIL c
FOR v = a TO b [STEP s] … NEXT [v]
EXIT FOR | EXIT WHILE | EXIT REPEAT
CASE expr OF
  WHEN v1, v2   …
  WHEN v3       …
  OTHERWISE     …
ENDCASE
TRY … CATCH … ENDTRY
ERROR n [, msg$]                          ' raise an error
```

CASE compares the selector with each WHEN value in turn (numbers or strings; a mismatch of type is an error), runs the first branch that matches, or OTHERWISE, and continues after ENDCASE. CASE, WHEN, OTHERWISE and ENDCASE must each start a line, as the other block keywords do (a WHEN branch can follow on the same line after :). EXIT WHILE, EXIT REPEAT and EXIT FOR continue after the matching WEND, UNTIL or NEXT statement. ERROR n, msg$ gives ERR = n, ERR$ = msg$ and an error report of msg$, line L. ERROR n alone uses the ROM's message for n if there is one, and otherwise reports Error n, line L (v0.10; it printed Error $00 before), with ERR$ = "".

Data

[LET] v = expr, DIM, SWAP a, b, DATA, READ, RESTORE [procname] (from the first DATA line after that DEF), CLEAR [ramtop] (forgets the variables, open loops and PROC calls, so use it at the top level; CLEAR n also moves RAMTOP to n, with the stacks, direct line and heap below it, and needs n − 4,864 (on 16K, n − 2,048) above the variables; typed directly, the rest of the line is not run), RANDOMIZE [n]

Screen and text

Statement	Notes
CLS	Clears with ATTR_P
PRINT [AT r,c;] [TAB(c);] items	; means no gap. , jumps to the next 16-column zone. ' starts a new line.
INPUT ["prompt";] v [, v…]	As built: each variable gets its own input line at the print position, edited with the console keys (EDIT and the marker keys are off). A number is read as by VAL.
INK n, PAPER n, FLASH 0/1, BRIGHT 0/1, INVERSE 0/1, OVER 0/1	Can also appear inline in PRINT. 8 means transparent.
BORDER n	

Columns in AT and TAB are **0–63**. Rows are 0–23. Row 23 is available to PRINT as long as no INPUT is pending.

Graphics (256×192 pixels, origin bottom-left; y = 0–191, since OpticOS keeps no permanent lower screen; INPUT temporarily uses row 23)

PLOT x,y, DRAW dx,dy (relative, Bresenham), DRAW TO x,y (absolute). (CIRCLE was dropped in v0.7, decision 8.) There are no Sinclair arcs: DRAW dx,dy,angle is a non-goal.

Sound

`BEEP dur, pitch` works as on Sinclair, with pitch in semitones from middle C. (`SOUND` was dropped in v0.7, decision 10; machine code can call BEEPER at `$03B5`.)

Machine and I/O

`POKE a,b`, `DPOKE a,w`, `OUT port,b`, `CALL addr` and `WAIT n`. (Register arguments for CALL were dropped in v0.8, decision 13: POKE them, or use USR.) `WAIT n` halts for n frames.

Tape

```
SAVE "name"                    ' program
SAVE "name" AUTO procname      ' runs that PROC (no parameters) after loading
SAVE "name" CODE start, len
LOAD "name" | LOAD ""          ' program (OpticOS or legacy)
LOAD "" CODE [start]
VERIFY …                       ' same forms as LOAD
' v0.8, decision 13: SAVE/LOAD/VERIFY "" SCREEN$ and CAT were dropped from
' OpticBASIC (SCREEN$ is CODE 16384,6912); legacy loaders keep LOAD "" SCREEN$
```

Direct-mode commands

`RUN [procname]` (with a name: the prepass, then a call of that PROC; at its end OpticOS returns to the prompt), `LIST`, `NEW`, `AUTO`, `EDIT` (key). `FREE` is a function: `PRINT FREE`. (`CONT` and `FIND` were dropped in v0.7, decision 10.) Any statement can also be typed in direct mode.

4.5 Functions

Group	Functions
Maths	`ABS SGN INT SQR EXP LN LOG SIN COS TAN ATN PI RND RND(n) MAX(a,b) MIN(a,b)` (ASN and ACS were dropped in v0.6 to save ROM; use `ATN(x/SQR(1-x*x))`)
String	`LEN LEFT$ RIGHT$ MID$ CHR$ ASC STR$ VAL INSTR(a$,b$[,start]) STRING$(n,s$) HEX$(n) UPPER$`
Input	`INKEY$`, `KEY(k$)` (true while the key for the first character of k$ is held: letters, digits and space; read straight from the matrix, so several keys can be tested at once, which suits games). `JOY` was dropped in v0.8; use `IN 31` for a Kempston joystick.
Machine	`PEEK DPEEK IN(port) USR(addr)` (returns BC, as Sinclair does), `FRAMES`, `FREE` (bytes between the variables and the string heap)
Errors	`ERR`, `ERR$` (`ERRLINE`, `ERRPROC$`, `POINT`, `ATTR` and `SCREEN$(r,c)` were dropped in v0.7, decision 10)

4.6 Error handling

`TRY` pushes a frame holding the stack pointer and the address of its `CATCH`. An error, whether raised by the ROM or by `ERROR n`, unwinds the control stack to the nearest TRY frame. Along the way it restores LOCALs and drops FOR, WHILE and PROC frames, then continues after `CATCH`. Without a TRY, execution stops and the message is printed with the line's position, for example `Division by zero, line 57`. That line becomes the current line, so EDIT brings it up at once. BREAK (CAPS+SPACE) is error 1. As built, BREAK and STOP cannot be caught by TRY.

4.7 Sample programs

Bouncing ball (64-column text; UDGs were dropped in v0.7, so the ball is the letter O)

```
' Bouncing ball: SPACE stops it
DEF PROC move
  PRINT AT y%, x%; " ";
  x% = x% + dx%: y% = y% + dy%
  IF x% <= 0 OR x% >= 63 THEN dx% = -dx%: BEEP 0.01, 24
  IF y% <= 1 OR y% >= 22 THEN dy% = -dy%: BEEP 0.01, 12
  PRINT AT y%, x%; "O";
ENDPROC
BORDER 1: PAPER 0: INK 5: CLS
PRINT AT 0, 0; "Bouncing ball - SPACE to stop"
x% = 10: y% = 5: dx% = 1: dy% = 1
FOR n% = 1 TO 300
  move
  WAIT 1
  IF KEY(" ") THEN EXIT FOR
NEXT
PRINT AT 23, 0; "Bounces done: "; n%;
```

The ball takes one text column, so x% runs through 0–63. This version is in the user manual and is run by its test script.

Guess the number, with error handling and a recursive function

```
DEF FN fact(n)
  IF n <= 1 THEN RETURN 1
  RETURN n * fact(n - 1)
ENDFN

secret% = RND(100)
tries% = 0
PRINT "I'm thinking of a number 1-100.  (10! = "; fact(10); ")"
REPEAT
  TRY
    INPUT "Guess"; g%
  CATCH
    PRINT "Numbers only, please ("; ERR$; ")"
    g% = 0
  ENDTRY
  tries% = tries% + 1
  CASE SGN(g% - secret%) OF
    WHEN -1: PRINT g%; " is too low"
    WHEN  1: PRINT g%; " is too high"
    OTHERWISE: PRINT "Got it in "; tries%; " tries"
  ENDCASE
UNTIL g% = secret%
```

4.8 Implementation status (as built, phase 5 complete)

Everything in §4.1–§4.7 is the target language. This table shows what the ROM actually does after phase 5b. Phase 5 works through the "not yet" column (§11).

Area	Built	Not yet
Structure	`DEF name(params)` … `ENDPROC`, `DEF name(params)` … `RETURN v` … `ENDFN`, one-line `DEF name(p) = expr` (the words `PROC` and `FN` after `DEF` are optional, and `FN` is optional in a call), dynamic `LOCAL`, recursion, bare-name PROC calls, `END`, `STOP`, `REM`, `'`	– (arrays by reference dropped, decision 13)
Control flow	one-line and block `IF` / `ELSEIF` / `ELSE` / `ENDIF`, `WHILE` / `WEND`, `REPEAT` / `UNTIL`, `FOR` … `NEXT [v]`, `TRY` / `CATCH` / `ENDTRY`, `ERROR n`, `CASE` / `WHEN` / `OTHERWISE` / `ENDCASE`, `EXIT WHILE` / `REPEAT` / `FOR`, `ERROR n [, msg$]`	–
Data	`LET` or bare assignment, `DIM` (up to 3 dimensions, base 0), `RANDOMIZE`, `DATA` / `READ` / `RESTORE` (a DATA statement must start its line; items are any expressions; RUN restores), `SWAP a, b` (numbers, integers, strings or elements of the same type), `RESTORE procname`, `CLEAR [ramtop]`	–

Area	Built	Not yet
Screen	`CLS`, `PRINT` / `?` with `;` `,` `'` `AT` `TAB`, `INK`, `PAPER`, `BORDER`, `INPUT`	–
Sound and machine	`POKE`, `DPOKE`, `WAIT`, `BEEP dur, pitch` (pitch from about −24 to 69), `OUT port, b`, `CALL addr`	– (`CALL` register arguments dropped, decision 13)
Tape	`SAVE "name"`, `SAVE "name" CODE start, length`, `LOAD "name"` / `LOAD ""` (OpticOS or legacy program), `LOAD "name" CODE [start]`, `VERIFY` with the same forms, `SAVE "name" AUTO procname`	– (OpticBASIC `SCREEN$` forms and `CAT` dropped, decision 13)
Direct mode	`RUN`, `LIST`, `NEW`, `AUTO`, `EDIT` key, any statement, `RUN procname`	–
Functions	`ABS SGN INT SQR EXP LN LOG SIN COS TAN ATN PI RND RND(n) MAX MIN LEN LEFT$ RIGHT$ MID$ CHR$ ASC STR$ VAL PEEK ERR TRUE FALSE INKEY$ FRAMES INSTR(a$,b$[,start]) STRING$(n,s$) HEX$(n) UPPER$(s$) ERR$ IN(port) USR(addr) DPEEK(addr) KEY(k$) FREE`	–

Differences from the text above, as built:

- BREAK cannot be caught by TRY (nor can STOP); it always returns to the prompt.
- An uncaught error prints `message, line n` on the screen and makes that line current. There is no status bar.
- The DEF table built by the prepass lies just above the program (§7.2), and every program edit clears the variables.
- `TAB` takes its column in brackets, `TAB(c)`; `TAB c` is a syntax error.
- Nesting is limited by the stacks below RAMTOP. Since v0.10 (decision 15) their sizes depend on the RAM: on a 48K machine the machine stack is 2,048 bytes, the control stack 2,048 and the value stack 512 (v0.11 halved the v0.10 sizes); on 16K they are 512, 768 and 512. Measured on 48K: a recursive FN used inside an expression nests 56 deep (`fact(33)` works; `fact(34)` is an Overflow, because 34! is beyond the number range), a recursive PROC with one parameter 141 deep, and one with a LOCAL as well 86 deep. Before v0.10 the limits were 12, 51 and 31 (v0.10 itself gave 116, 291 and 176). On 16K they are about the same as before v0.10 (a PROC 53 deep).

5. Program storage

5.1 Line format

```
+-----+----------------------------+------+-----+
| len | tokens and operands …      | $0D  | len |
+-----+----------------------------+------+-----+
```

- `len` (1 byte, 3–255) appears at **both ends** of the line. Walking forward is `ptr += len` and walking backward is `ptr -= (ptr-1)^`. Both are O(1), so the editor never needs line numbers. The overhead is 3 bytes per line, against Sinclair's 5 (number, length and ENTER).
- The program starts at `$5DF0` (PROG; `$5DD0` until v0.8, when 32 bytes went to `ERROR n, msg$`) and ends with a `$00` sentinel.
- **Indentation is not stored.** The tokeniser strips leading spaces. LIST and the editor recompute indentation from the block keywords, at 2 spaces per level, while they display. The program always looks tidy and no bytes are wasted.
- Spaces inside a line are kept only where they are needed to separate words, so that LIST shows a canonical spacing.

5.2 Token encoding

Byte(s)	Meaning
`$80–$FF`	Keyword tokens (one byte, 128 slots). Statements come first, so they can be dispatched by `token-$80`.
`$01 t h n name…`	Identifier: `t` = type (float, int, string, or array of each), `h` = 6-bit hash, `n` = length, then the lower-case name
`$02 lo hi`	16-bit integer literal
`$03 lo hi`	Hex literal (LIST shows it as `$…`)
`$04 lo hi`	Binary literal
`$05 e m m m m`	Float literal (5 bytes)
`$06 n chars…`	String literal
`$07 lo hi`	**Link slot**: a forward or back reference filled in by the prepass (§7.2)
`$20–$7E`	Punctuation and operators as ASCII. Two-character operators (<=, >=, <>, <<, >>) have their own tokens.

Link slots follow `IF` (block form), `ELSEIF`, `ELSE`, `WHILE`, `WEND`, `REPEAT`, `CASE`, `WHEN`, `TRY`, `CATCH`, `DEF PROC` and `DEF FN`. Each is 3 bytes, and the prepass patches it with the address of the matching keyword. Identifiers and literals are self-describing, so the detokeniser rebuilds the exact source text. The only change is that numbers come back normalised, so `1.50` lists as `1.5`.

5.3 How the editor addresses lines

The editor keeps one pointer, to the current line. Moving up or down is a single `len` step in either direction. Error messages give a line's position (its ordinal, counted from the start) for display only. Ordinals are never stored and never used in GOTO.

5.4 RAM layout (48K)

```
$4000-$57FF  bitmap            $5800-$5AFF  attributes
$5B00-$5BFF  edit-line buffer and tokeniser workspace (free for machine code once BASIC has stopped)
$5C00-$5CB5  system variables (compatible subset at Sinclair addresses, §9)
$5CB6-$5CCA  channel table (K, S, R; Sinclair layout, so 23739 = channel S output, low byte)
$5CCB-$5D4F  OpticOS extended system variables: 32 hash heads (64), A%-Z% (52), editor state (7) …
$5D50-$5DCF  input line (126 characters + terminator)
$5DD0-$5DEB  EMBUF: the message of the last ERROR n, msg$ (28 characters)
$5DEC-$5DEF  the tape signature "OB" 1 0, written just before a program is saved
$5DF0        PROG     -> program lines … $00, then the DEF table
             VARS     -> variable records (grow up)
             (free)
             STRHEAP  <- string heap (grows down from STKBOT)
             STKBOT   -> direct line (256), value stack, control stack and machine stack
                         below RAMTOP: 512 / 2,048 / 2,048 bytes on 48K, 512 / 768 / 512 on 16K
RAMTOP (default $FF57) +1 -> 168 bytes kept free to P_RAMT $FFFF, where Sinclair keeps its UDGs
             (the UDG variable points here for machine code; OpticOS does not print UDGs)
```

The legacy shim loads a Sinclair program at `$5CCB` over the extended variables. That is safe because the shim only uses the compatible variables. Returning to OpticOS after legacy mode triggers a warm reset.

---

6. The editor and the 64-column display

6.1 The 4-pixel font (default)

- **Format.** 96 characters (32–127), each 4 pixels wide by 8 rows. **Two glyphs are packed per byte row**: characters 32+2k and 33+2k share 8 bytes, with the even code in the high nibble and

the odd code in the low nibble. That makes 48 pairs × 8 bytes = **384 bytes**, at `$3E80`–`$3FFF`, aligned so that a pair's 8 bytes never cross a 256-byte page (so `INC E` steps through them).
- **Design grid.** Glyphs are 3 pixels wide with a fourth blank column, so neighbours have a gap. Row 0 is blank (line spacing), capitals and digits use rows 1–5, and descenders use rows 6–7. Lower case uses a 4-row x-height. The artwork is original and drawn by us in `font4.txt` (ASCII art), in the spirit of Tasword Two, not copied from it (§1.3).
- **The copyright sign.** Code 127 is the **editor cursor/wrap block**, not ©. A © is illegible at 3 pixels wide, so **the font has no © glyph** and the banner uses ASCII `(c)`.
- **Codes 128–255 print as ?** (as built, checked in v0.9). Block graphics 128–143 were planned, generated in code, but were not built, and UDG printing was dropped in v0.7 (decision 8). The 168 bytes above RAMTOP are still kept free, as on Sinclair, for machine code that expects them.

6.2 The fast print routine

The screen byte is `col >> 1`. An even column means the high nibble, so the destination mask is M = `$F0`, and an odd column gives M = `$0F`. The glyph nibble sits on the side given by `(code-32) & 1`. If that side differs from the column parity, the nibble is swapped with 4 × `RRCA`. A masked merge then writes the nibble without disturbing the other character:

```
; DE -> 8 font bytes of the pair, HL -> top screen byte, C = M, B = 8
row:  ld   a,(de)      ;  7
      ; rrca x4        ; 16  (only when parity differs; separate loop copy)
      xor  (hl)        ;  7
      and  c           ;  4
      xor  (hl)        ;  7  -> new nibble in M, old screen bits elsewhere
      ld   (hl),a      ;  7
      inc  e           ;  4
      inc  h           ;  4
      djnz row         ; 13
```

That is 53 T per row (69 with the swap), so **424–552 T for the 8 rows**. Setup adds about 280 T: channel dispatch, the screen address from row and column, the font address, the attribute write and advancing the cursor. **Total: about 700–830 T per character**, or about 750 T on average. A full 64×24 screen of 1,536 characters takes about 1.15 M T, which is about **16 frames (0.33 s)**.

- **Pair fast path.** When two characters start at an even column with plain attributes (the normal case for LIST, editor redraw and string PRINT), both nibbles are combined and the whole byte is stored with no masking: `ld a,(de1) / and $F0 / ld c,a / ld a,(de2) / and $0F / or c / ld (hl),a`, with the swaps as needed. This costs about 75 T per row, or about **450 T per character** including setup, and an editor redraw takes about 0.2 s.
- **INVERSE / OVER** use a slower general path. `CPL` before the merge gives inverse. OVER replaces the merge with `and c / xor (hl)`.
- **Scrolling** moves 23 text rows up one, exactly as in 32-column mode: 5,888 bytes by `LDI` runs, about 110–125 k T, which is under 2 frames.

6.3 MODE 32 (dropped in v0.7, decision 8; kept for the record)

`MODE 32` switches the print routine to a whole-byte path.

- If `CHARS` holds its default value, glyphs are the 4-pixel font with each pixel doubled horizontally, using a 16-byte nibble-to-byte table. That is chunky but readable, and it costs no font storage.
- If a program has pointed `CHARS` at an 8×8 font in RAM, as games and the legacy shim might, that font is used directly.

The cost is about **110 bytes**: the table plus the extra paths. A full 8×8 ROM font at `$3D00` would look better in MODE 32 and restore `$3D00` compatibility, but at **+768 bytes** it would leave only about 240 bytes of margin, so it is not included for now. It may be revisited in Phase 5 if the margin allows (§12).

6.4 Attributes at 64 columns: colour-clash policy

One attribute byte covers an 8×8 cell, which is **two 64-column characters** (columns 2k and 2k+1).

- **Last writer wins.** Printing any character writes ATTR_T into its cell, so it also recolours its neighbour. Colour 8 (transparent) and `OVER` keep their Sinclair meanings, so `INK 8`/`PAPER 8` leave the cell's colours alone. Since v0.13 this holds for PLOT and DRAW as well as PRINT: each writes a cell's attribute through one routine (`attr_set`), which keeps the bits that MASK_T marks transparent (ink `$07`, paper `$38`, bright `$40`, flash `$80`). INK, PAPER, BRIGHT and FLASH as statements copy both ATTR_P and MASK_P to ATTR_T and MASK_T; before v0.13 they copied only ATTR_P, and PLOT ignored the mask.
- **Guidance**, shown in the manual and in the "Colour" example: change colours on even columns. `PRINT AT r,c; INK n;` with an odd `c` recolours column `c−1` too.
- **The editor is monochrome.** It uses one paper/ink pair, so the text never clashes. Colour is used only on the status bar (row 23, a whole row) and for whole-line highlights, such as the error line in red paper, which never clash because they cover full rows.
- **The cursor** is drawn by XOR-ing a 4×8 nibble block, not by FLASH, because FLASH would blink both characters in the cell. The ISR toggles it every 16 frames.
- `ATTR(r,c)` returns the attribute of cell `(r, c>>1)` in MODE 64.

6.5 The line editor (agreed for phase 4, v0.4)

There is no full-screen editor. Editing follows the Sinclair pattern: a **current line**, marked > when listed, which you move with the cursor keys and copy into the input line with EDIT.

- **The current line** is held as a pointer to the line (`CURL`), not as a number. 0 means "above the first line". It is set by entering, editing or deleting a line, by the cursor keys, and by an uncaught error (the failing line becomes current). NEW and LOAD reset it.
- **LIST** lists the whole program with > in front of the current line. **Cursor up/down** (CAPS+7 / CAPS+6) move the marker one line and relist about ten lines either side of it, on a cleared screen. Moving up from the first line goes above it, so the next inserted line goes at the top.
- **The input line** holds up to 126 characters (two rows at 64 columns), with a cursor. CAPS+5 / CAPS+8 move left and right, characters are inserted at the cursor, and DELETE (CAPS+0) removes the character to its left. The prompt shows the mode: `]` direct, + AUTO, * editing a line.
- **EDIT** (CAPS+1) detokenises the current line into the input line, without its indentation, and the prompt becomes *. ENTER tokenises the line and puts it in place of the current line. Pressing EDIT again empties the input line, so **EDIT, EDIT, ENTER deletes the current line**, and the line before it becomes current.
- **Entering new lines: AUTO.** Typed lines run at once, unless the `AUTO` command has been given. In AUTO mode (prompt +) each line typed goes in **after the current line** and becomes the current line, so a program is typed from top to bottom. An empty line ends AUTO mode. This replaces the temporary > prefix of phase 3.
- After any change to the program, the lines around the marker are relisted, as on the Spectrum.
- Every change to the program clears the variables and forces a new prepass. The variables sit just above the program and the DEF table, and string back-pointers point into them, so keeping them would cost more than it is worth.

6.6 Keys

Keywords are typed **letter by letter**. The tokeniser recognises them when the line is entered, and the keyword legends on the keys are ignored.

Key	Action
Letters and digits	Lower case. CAPS SHIFT gives upper case.

Key	Action
SYMBOL SHIFT + key	The red symbol printed on the key (", =, +, <, ; …), as on Sinclair
CAPS + SYMBOL, then a key	E mode, one shot: `[ ] { } \ | ~` on keys Y U F G D S A
CAPS+5 / CAPS+8	Cursor left / right in the input line
CAPS+7 / CAPS+6	Move the current-line marker up / down and relist
CAPS+0	Delete the character left of the cursor
CAPS+1 (EDIT)	Copy the current line into the input line; a second press empties it
ENTER	Run the line, or (in AUTO or EDIT) put it into the program
CAPS+SPACE	BREAK

Direct commands are typed at the `]` prompt: `RUN`, `LIST`, `NEW`, `AUTO`, `LOAD ""`, or any statement.

6.7 Boot screen

The cold-start screen (layout agreed with Nathan, 13 November 2026) is:

Row	Content
0	**Colour bar.** Attribute cells only, with no pixels set. There are 16 swatches, each 2 attribute cells wide, across all 32 columns: black, blue, red, magenta, green, cyan, yellow and white, first normal and then BRIGHT. Bright black is included so the layout stays even. Each cell's ink equals its paper.
1	Blank
2	`OpticOS (c) 2026 Optica Technology Design`, white on black
3	`OpticBASIC v1.0`, the name and version of the BASIC
4	Blank
5	The prompt `]`, with the cursor at column 2

Rows 1–23 are white ink on black paper, and the border is black. **`]` followed by a space is the OpticOS direct-mode prompt everywhere.** It appears at boot and again whenever a command finishes or an error is reported. The prompt and its space use two of the 64 columns, so a console line holds up to 61 characters plus the cursor. The colour bar is an ordinary screen row, so it scrolls away with the console text. The mock-up is `assets/opticos_boot.png`, and the rig's boot test compares the ROM's screen with it pixel for pixel.

Start-up sound (v0.7, Nathan's request). Once the boot screen is drawn, and before the first prompt accepts keys, OpticOS plays the BBC Micro's two power-on tones **in reverse order**, through the standard `BEEPER` routine (`chime`, 20 bytes of code, plus a 3-byte call from the boot code). The BBC sound is described, not copied. Its sources:

- The low first tone is not produced by software. It is the SN76489 sound chip's power-on state, playing until the MOS initialises the 6522 VIA and silences the chip. Users on stardot ("Default sn76489 sound chip state", stardot.org.uk/forums/viewtopic.php?t=16106) measured about 900 ms of it, then about 50 ms of silence. The MDFS archive ("Only one beep", mdfsnet.f9.co.uk, 2009) explains the same thing. Its pitch is about **122 Hz**, the chip's lowest tone: 4 MHz / (32 × 1023) = 122.2 Hz.
- The high second tone is an ordinary BELL (VDU 7). It sits after the RAM size ("16K" or "32K") in the start-up message, which is why only a hard reset beeps. The default BELL is SOUND pitch **101**, for duration **6** (twentieths of a second, so 0.3 s). Source: *Acorn Electron Advanced User Guide*, OSBYTE &D5/&D6, where the BBC MOS 1.2 defaults are the same. On the BBC User Guide's pitch scale (53 = middle C, 4 steps per semitone), pitch 101 is the C an octave above middle C, **523.25 Hz**.

	BBC Micro (cold boot)	OpticOS (reversed)
First	about 122 Hz, about 0.9 s	523.25 Hz, 0.3 s (BEEPER DE=157, HL=806)

	BBC Micro (cold boot)	OpticOS (reversed)
Gap	about 50 ms	two frames (40 ms, `HALT` ×2)
Second	523.25 Hz, 0.3 s	122.2 Hz, 0.9 s (DE=110, HL=3550)

The rig measures 523.3 Hz for 0.30 s, then 121.9 Hz for 0.90 s. The chime adds about 1.25 s to the cold start, with interrupts off while BEEPER runs. FRAMES does not advance during it, and keys pressed during it are not seen. The rigs now wait 150 frames, not 80, after power-on, and tape loading is unaffected because `LOAD ""` is typed after the prompt appears. Warm starts (NEW) do not play the sound.

---

7. Interpreter design

7.1 The tokeniser

The tokeniser makes a single pass over the edit buffer. At each word boundary it looks the word up in the keyword table. The table is sorted and grouped by first letter, with a 26-entry index of first-letter offsets (52 bytes), and each keyword ends with bit 7 set. A match must be followed by a non-identifier character, and `%`, `$` or `(` after a keyword are allowed by context. Words that don't match become identifiers: the tokeniser computes their hash and stores the type, hash, length and name. Numbers are converted to binary with the maths package's string-to-number routine. The detokeniser does the reverse, plus indentation, and serves LIST, the editor and error display.

7.2 The prepass (resolver)

The prepass runs at RUN, or at the first CONT after a load or edit. It takes about 30–60 ms per KB of program. In one linear pass it:

1. Records every `DEF PROC` and `DEF FN` in a **symbol table** in a reserved RAM area just above the program: hash, name pointer and line address, 5 bytes each. It reports duplicates. A DEF whose name was tokenised as a keyword (`DEF PROC run`, `DEF FN cos(x)`, `DEF cos(x)`) is error 21, "Keyword as name", reported at the DEF line (v0.13); before, it was stored silently and could never be called.
2. Matches blocks with a small temporary stack and **patches the link slots**:
3. `IF` → its `ELSEIF`, `ELSE` or `ENDIF`
4. `ELSE` → `ENDIF`
5. `WHILE` ↔ `WEND`
6. `REPEAT` ← `UNTIL`
7. `CASE` → each `WHEN` → `ENDCASE`
8. `TRY` → `CATCH` → `ENDTRY`
9. `DEF` → its end, so that execution can skip over definitions it falls into
10. Reports structural errors before anything runs, for example "ENDIF without IF, line 40".

At run time, a false `IF`, an exiting `WHILE` or a skipped `DEF` costs one pointer load. There are no scans.

7.3 Statement dispatch and the control stack

The interpreter's registers are HL = text pointer (`CH_ADD`) and SP = the machine stack, which is also the control stack. Each statement token is looked up in a 2-byte jump table. Control frames are pushed on the Z80 stack with a type byte:

Frame	Contents	Bytes
FOR (float)	type, variable pointer, limit (5), step (5), loop pointer	15

Frame	Contents	Bytes
FOR (integer fast)	type, variable pointer, limit (2), step (2), loop pointer	9
WHILE / REPEAT	type, loop pointer	3
PROC / FN	type, return pointer, saved-locals count, saved ERR frame	6
LOCAL entry	variable pointer, old value (2, 5 or 3 bytes)	4–7
TRY	type, CATCH address, saved SP	5
CASE	type, ENDCASE address, selector value	3–8

ERR_SP points at the current error frame. RST 8 unwinds to that frame. NEXT, WEND and ENDPROC check the frame type. When they find the wrong one, they report "NEXT without FOR" and similar errors. Before each push, a stack-overflow check compares SP against STRHEAP plus a 64-byte guard.

7.4 Variable lookup

The type byte and 6-bit hash are stored in the identifier token. There are 32 chain heads, indexed by hash and type. Each variable record holds: next pointer (2), name length (1), name, value (2, 5 or 3 bytes, or an array header).

Lookup: take the head, walk the chain, and compare the length and then the name with a short CPI-style loop. A typical program has under 50 variables, so chains average fewer than 2 entries, and a lookup costs about 150–250 T. A%–Z% skip lookup entirely at about 40 T. Creating a variable appends at VARS end, which sits below the heap, so the gap shrinks.

A later optimisation, kept out of the budget, is an inline cache: a 2-byte pointer slot tagged with a RUN generation counter. It would cost 3 bytes per identifier use, which is why it isn't in the plan.

7.5 The integer fast path

The expression evaluator is precedence-climbing. Values live on a small value stack in workspace as 5-byte entries. Integers of every kind are held in **small-integer form** (`00 sign lo hi 00`).

For + - * < = …, DIV, MOD, AND, OR and shifts, if both operands are small integers, 16-bit Z80 code runs and checks for overflow. Only on overflow does it promote both operands to float and retry. FOR with integer start, limit and step uses the 9-byte frame and 16-bit compare. Literals are pre-converted, so there is no ASCII parsing at run time. Between them, these are where the speed comes from.

7.6 Strings and garbage collection

- The heap grows **down** from STKBOT. Each heap string is `[back-pointer 2][length 1][chars]`, and the back-pointer points at the descriptor that owns it.
- Temporaries made during expression evaluation go on the heap with back-pointer 0. They are freed at the end of each statement by resetting the heap mark (no GC).
- **Compaction** runs when an allocation fails. It is a sliding pass from the top of the heap down:
- If a block's back-pointer still points at a descriptor that refers to this block, the block is kept: it slides up and the descriptor is fixed up.
- Otherwise the block is dropped.
- The pass is O(heap) and needs no mark phase or extra memory, at about 300 bytes of code.
- The worst case is about 25 ms per 10 KB of heap.

7.7 Maths package

- **Format.** Sinclair-compatible 5-byte layout. That keeps STACK-BC-style interoperability possible, and the small-integer form provides the fast path.

- **Core.** Add, subtract, multiply (32×32 shift-and-add), divide (restoring), normalise and round, compare, and int↔float conversion.
- **Transcendentals.** Range reduction plus short Chebyshev or minimax series, driven by a compact **internal byte-code** (our own opcodes) that runs coefficient tables. That is far smaller than open-coding each function.

Function	Method
SIN, COS	Reduce to ±π/4, 6 terms
ATN	Reduce to [0, 1], 8 terms. (ASN and ACS were dropped in v0.6.)
LN	Mantissa in [0.5, 1], 7 terms
EXP	2^n × series
SQR	Newton iteration, 4–5 steps
^	EXP(LN) with an integer fast path for small exponents

- **Accuracy target**: an error of 1 unit in the last place or less on the core operations, and 2 or less on the transcendentals, checked against Python `mpmath`.

---

8. 16K ROM memory map and budget

8.1 Fixed points in the ROM

```
$0000-$006F  RST vectors, $0038 ISR entry, $0066 NMI         (fixed)
$03B5        BEEPER          $04C2 SA-BYTES   $0556 LD-BYTES
$05E3/$05E7  LD-EDGE-2/1     $096F RET        $0D6B CLS   $0DAF CL-ALL
$1601        CHAN-OPEN       $203C PR-STRING  $22AA PIXEL-ADD
$3E80-$3FFF  4-pixel font, 384 bytes                        (fixed)
everything else: modules packed into the gaps by the link script (first-fit, largest first)
```

8.2 Budget

#	Module	Bytes, as built (v0.8, phase 5 complete)
1	Restarts, NMI, reset, RAM test, sysvars, channels	300
2	Boot banner + version text, calls	68
3	Interrupt routine, keyboard scan, key tables	355
4	64-column print, control codes, colours, scroll, CLS, RST 16	578
8	Tape low level: SA-BYTES, LD-BYTES, edges, tape_ret	310
10	Sound: BEEPER	82
26	Errors: RST 8 handler and messages	475
9	Tape commands: SAVE / LOAD / VERIFY, CODE, headers, name match	422
27	Legacy loader shim (interpreter, expressions, PRINT)	845
13	Number output for the legacy shim and console (pr_dec, pr_hex)	50
12	Float core (+ - * /, normalise, compare, conversions, small-int ops)	1,422
13	Number <-> string (STR$/PRINT formatting, VAL)	709

#	Module	Bytes, as built (v0.8, phase 5 complete)
14	Transcendentals, byte-code runner, coefficient tables	1,148
18	Expression evaluator and functions	1,330
17	Variables, arrays, string heap + GC, value and control stacks	1,301
15	Tokeniser, keyword table, LIST	1,800
19	Interpreter: run loop, statements, prepass, PROC/FN, TRY	2,369
19-20	CASE, EXIT, ERROR n [,msg$], CLEAR [n], PROC-name lookup	302
25	Direct mode and console: input line with insert/delete/cursor	422
24	Line editor: marker, LIST around it, cursor up/down, EDIT	268
25	INPUT, DATA / READ / RESTORE	183
11	Graphics: PLOT, DRAW, DRAW TO	238
10	BEEP, OUT, DPOKE, CALL, SWAP; start-up chime	216
18	String and machine functions: INSTR STRING$ HEX$ UPPER$ ERR$ IN USR DPEEK KEY FREE	465
28	Fixed-address stubs (CHAN-OPEN, PR-STRING, PIXEL-ADD, $096F)	78
7	4-pixel font	384
	Total (v0.2 budget: 15,374)	**16,163**
	Free (of 16,384)	**221** (margin rule: at least 256; 261 before v0.13's colour-8 and keyword-name fixes, 264 before the trap-safe tape layout, 283 before the longer boot banner)

The ROM builds its own version of this table (`build/bytes.md`, from `tools/check_layout.py`). The free bytes are spread over twelve gaps between the fixed addresses (the largest is 62 bytes).

Rebalance after phase 3 (v0.3). The maths (items 12–14, +882 bytes) and the interpreter (items 15–22, +1,450 bytes) came out larger than the v0.2 estimates. As agreed, the size reduction is left to phase 5, and the budgets above now record what was built, with room kept for the features each module still lacks. The ROM built so far fits, with 2,543 bytes free (well above the 256-byte margin rule). The free space is in seven gaps between fixed addresses, the largest being 613 bytes, so later modules must be split to fit.

Rebalance after phase 4 (v0.4). The full-screen editor (1,400) is replaced by a Sinclair-style line editor, built in 585 bytes and budgeted at 600. That recovers 800 bytes of the overrun. The ROM as built has 1,958 bytes free, spread over seven gaps (the largest now 397 bytes).

Rebalance in phase 5a (v0.6). ASN and ACS were dropped (−87 bytes with their keywords). INPUT, DATA/READ/RESTORE and SAVE/LOAD/VERIFY with CODE were built in 501 bytes (212 + 289), less than their budgets. The v0.4 projection had not counted the keyword table for the keywords still to come, so row 15–17 now includes about 270 bytes for them, and row 26 includes room for a few more messages.

Rebalance in phase 5b (v0.7). Nathan's cuts (decisions 8–11) remove MODE 32, UDG printing, CIRCLE, LABEL/GOTO, SOUND, SCREEN$(r,c), ATTR, POINT, FIND, CONT, ERRLINE and ERRPROC$ from the plan. The squeezes so far saved 222 bytes: GET-CHAR, NEXT-CHAR and an "integer expression" helper moved into the free restarts `$18`, `$20` and `$30`, so about 80 three-byte `CALL`s became one-byte `RST`s (186); RND keeps its state in registers (21); a shared "number 0–255" helper (15). Graphics,

colours, BEEP, the string and machine functions and SWAP were then built in 820 bytes plus their keywords. The start-up chime (§6.7) adds 23 bytes. One planned squeeze was tried and rejected: sending small integers through the float path in STR$ saves 36 bytes but makes printing an integer about 15 times slower (about 80,000 T-states).

Rebalance in phase 5c (v0.8): the feature list is complete. Decision 13 drops array parameters by reference, `CALL` register arguments, `CAT`, the OpticBASIC `SCREEN$` tape forms and `JOY` (12 bytes back). The last maths squeezes save 39 bytes: COS from SIN ($\cos r = 2(½ - \sin^2(r/2))$, one polynomial fewer), EXP with 8 coefficients instead of 9, and a shorter VAL digit loop. They cost some accuracy in SIN and COS (worst case 1.81 ulp, was 1.07; see docs/maths.md). The largest saving was not in the plan: RST `$28`, which raised "Calculator not supported", now enters the maths byte-code runner, so its 37 calls take one byte instead of three, and the message went too (about 99 bytes). CASE, EXIT, `ERROR n, msg$`, CLEAR, FREE, KEY and the PROC-name forms of RUN, RESTORE and SAVE … AUTO were then built in about 500 bytes with their keywords. The ROM has 283 bytes free, so the 256-byte margin is kept. Fixing a line-number bug in error reports cost 2 bytes. The longer boot banner (`Optica Technology Design`, 7 more characters) then left 276 free.

The 4-pixel font saves 384 bytes compared with an 8×8 set. The 64-column print logic costs about 100 bytes more than a plain 32-column printer, so the change of display gained roughly 200 bytes overall. Adding an 8×8 font at `$3D00` would bring the total to 16,142, leaving a margin of 242 (1.5%). That is too thin, so the font is left out for now (§12).

8.3 Benchmarks

- **ZX81 8K ROM.** Floating point, BASIC, display, tape and a line editor in 8,192 bytes. That suggests a richer system in 16K is realistic.
- **Sinclair 48K ROM.** 16K, including a 768-byte font and a large calculator. It is generous in its token handling, and its syntax checking is folded into the run-time code.
- **BBC BASIC II.** 16K for the language alone. The screen, keyboard, tape and line editor live in the separate 16K MOS, and about 2–3K of the language ROM goes on the inline assembler. Without the assembler that leaves about 13K for language plus maths, which is the strongest warning against over-ambitious features. OpticBASIC is smaller (no assembler, no VDU system, simpler PRINT formatting), but it also carries its own "MOS".
- **Microsoft 8K BASIC** (8080 and 6502 versions, about 8–9K with floats) shows that the core interpreter plus floats can be done in about 7K.

8.4 Risks

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
The maths package and editor overrun by 20–30% (typical)	High	Margin, plus the cut list below
LD-EDGE timing mismatch breaks turbo loaders	Medium	Pulse-sweep tests against the reference in the rig. A loader compatibility corpus.
Fixed addresses fragment the ROM	Medium	Link script with gap packing. Small routines are kept to fill gaps.
64-column legibility on a real TV	Medium	Font tuning in Fuse with a CRT filter. MODE 32 as a fallback.
Float accuracy	Low to medium	mpmath test vectors

Cut list (about 900 bytes recoverable): CASE (150), ASN/ACS (80), `SCREEN$()` (60), CAT (60), CIRCLE (120), editor clipboard and join (150), `HEX$/STRING$/UPPER$` (90), and slimming the legacy shim to the minimal loader set (200).

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9. System variables

Policy. Keep the variables that machine code and loaders commonly touch at their **Sinclair addresses**, with the same meaning. Everything else in `$5C00–$5CB5` is reused for OpticOS internals, and `IY` is set to `$5C3A` whenever control passes to user code. This keeps `(IY+n)` habits harmless, and the OpticOS ISR does not rely on IY.

Address	Name	Kept?	Why
`$5C08`	LAST_K	Yes	Games read it for keys
`$5C09/0A`	REPDEL/REPPER	Yes	Commonly POKEd
`$5C36`	CHARS	Yes	Fonts in RAM. It also selects MODE 32 behaviour.
`$5C3A`	ERR_NR	Yes	IY base, RST 8
`$5C3B`	FLAGS	Bit 5 (new key) only	ISR and keyboard pollers
`$5C3D`	ERR_SP	Yes (OpticOS meaning: error frame)	Code that traps errors
`$5C48`	BORDCR	Yes	Restoring the border after a load
`$5C4F/51`	CHANS/CURCHL	Yes	RST 16 and CHAN-OPEN users
`$5C53`	PROG	Yes: the OpticOS program start `$5DF0` (24048), or `$5CCB` while a Sinclair loader is in memory. (Before v0.10 it wrongly held `$5D50`.) It is set at boot and on every NEW, LOAD and program edit.	`PEEK 23635` loaders
`$5C6B`	DF_SZ	Yes	Lower-screen size
`$5C76`	SEED	Yes	RND
`$5C78`	FRAMES (3)	Yes	Timing in many games
`$5C7B`	UDG	Yes (points to RAMTOP + 1; OpticOS itself does not print UDGs)	Machine code that finds the UDG area through it
`$5C7D`	COORDS	Yes	PLOT position
`$5C88`	S_POSN	Yes	Print position, stored as 64-column values in MODE 64
`$5C8D–$5C91`	ATTR_P, MASK_P, ATTR_T, MASK_T, P_FLAG	Yes	Colour handling
`$5CB0`	NMIADD	Yes	NMI hook
`$5CB2`	RAMTOP	Yes	CLEAR, and loaders
`$5CB4`	P_RAMT	Yes	Memory size
others	KSTATE, E_LINE, WORKSP, X_PTR …	Reused internally	Only Sinclair BASIC needs their meanings

New variables in `$5CCB–$5D4F`:

- `MODE`
- `FONT4`
- `VARS`, `STRHEAP`, `STKBOT`, `SYMTAB`
- `DIRTY` and the prepass generation counter
- editor state: top pointer and ordinal, cursor pointer and ordinal, column, clipboard
- the 32 hash heads (64 bytes)

- `A%`–`Z%` (52 bytes)

A magic byte and checksum on this area lets OpticOS detect corruption by machine code. A `RET` back from `CALL` into a damaged area causes a warm reset that keeps the program, rather than a crash.

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10. Build and test plan

10.1 Tools on the box

- **Assembler.** `pasmo 0.5.3`. Install it from `/workspace/debs/pasmo_0.5.3-8_amd64.deb` (`dpkg -x` into a local prefix if it isn't on PATH; today it isn't). Use `pasmo --bin opticos.asm build/opticos.rom build/opticos.sym`. The Python assembler `spectrum-ball/tools/zasm.py` is a fallback that produces identical output.
- **Emulator.** Fuse 1.6.0 (`fuse-emulator-sdl` and `libspectrum8` debs in `/workspace/debs`), driven by `ultimate/miremare/tools/fusectl.py`, which gives a private Xvfb, xdotool keys and screenshots. Load the ROM with: `fuse-sdl --machine 48 --rom-48 /workspace/newrom/build/opticos.rom --no-traps --no-fastload file.tap` Fuse's tape traps assume the Sinclair loader internals, so the real-signal path (`--no-traps`) is the authority. A second pass with traps on records whether fast loading happens to work.
- **Headless rig.** `z80core.c` / `libz80core.so` (copies in `spectrum-ball/tools` and `miremare/tools`), driven from Python through `spectest.py` and `headless.py`. Today the rig injects game code directly and **does not implement IX/IY (DD/FD prefixes)** or EAR input. Phase 0 extends it with:
- the DD/FD/DDCB/FDCB opcodes (needed for LD-BYTES, whose contract is IX-based)
- a ROM-boot mode from `$0000` with a 16K ROM write-protect
- an EAR input pulse stream generated from a TAP (the standard timings) and a MIC/EAR output recorder that turns pulses back into TAP
- memory-contention timing that is accurate enough for edge-loop tests.

10.2 Build checks (`make check`)

1. The image is exactly 16,384 bytes, and the fixed symbols sit at their addresses (checked from the symbol file).
2. `similarity_check.py` passes against `48.rom` (§1.3). The ROM is never copied into `build/`, and `.gitignore` covers `roms/`, `*.rom` from outside and `build/`.
3. A size report per module against the budget table. The build fails if margin drops below 256 bytes.

10.3 Test suites

Suite	How it works
Boot	Rig: the banner `OpticOS (c) 2026 Optica Technology Design` appears at row 0, read back with a Python decoder that converts screen bitmaps to text using our font. RAM test passes for 16K and 48K.
Keyboard	Inject matrix states. Check LAST_K, repeat and E mode.
Print	Pixel-exact checks at odd and even columns, pair path, INVERSE/OVER, attribute-cell policy, scrolling. T-state counts per character recorded (target ≤ 850 T masked, ≤ 500 T pair).
Maths	About 5,000 vectors against mpmath, with error in units of the last place. Integer fast path and overflow promotion.
Tokeniser	Round trip: source → tokens → LIST is identical after normalisation, across a corpus.
Interpreter	About 150 small `.obas` programs with expected console output, including the §4.7 samples, recursion, GC stress and every error message.

Suite	How it works
Editor	Scripted key sequences, then compare the program and screen.
Performance	PCW benchmarks BM1–BM8 under OpticOS and under the Sinclair reference in the rig. Target ≥ 3× on BM1–BM3.
Tape: save	SAVE → recorded pulses → TAP → byte-compare and parse. The original ROM in Fuse then loads OpticOS-saved CODE blocks.
Compatibility	`LOAD ""` with real-signal loading in Fuse (`--no-traps`): `/workspace/spectrum-ball/bounceball.tap`, `/workspace/rel/miremare.tap`, `miremare_demo.tap` and `miremare_sfx.tap`. Pass means the game reaches its title screen and responds to keys (screenshots compared with the earlier runs under the Sinclair ROM). Extend later with any TAPs Nathan supplies privately, which are never committed.
Edge timing	Sweep pulse lengths and compare the B returned by `$05E7` with the reference ROM, tolerance ±1.

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11. Phased plan

A "session" means one long working block, as with Mire Mare.

Phase	Content	Deliverables	Effort
0. Rig (done)	Add IX/IY, ROM boot, EAR in and out, and the screen-to-text decoder to the headless core. Build skeleton, link script, checks.	`tools/rig/`, `make check`, an empty 16K image	1 session
1. Boot, screen, keyboard, tape (done)	Reset and RAM test, ISR, keyboard, 4-pixel font artwork, 64-column print and scroll, MODE 32, channels and RST 16, BEEPER, SA/LD-BYTES at fixed addresses, the stubs, **the legacy shim**, and a minimal console.	A ROM that boots to the banner in Fuse. Bounce Ball and Mire Mare load and play via `LOAD ""` with no traps. Font sheet PNG.	3 sessions
2. Maths (done)	Float core, conversions, byte-code runner, transcendentals, RND	Maths library plus the mpmath test report	2 sessions
3. Interpreter (done)	Tokeniser and detokeniser, prepass, evaluator, statements, PROC/FN/LOCAL, loops, TRY, strings and GC, arrays, console-based direct mode. Graphics, sound and tape commands moved to phase 5.	Sample programs run. Benchmark report against Sinclair.	3–4 sessions
4. Editor (done)	Sinclair-style line editor (v0.4): current-line marker, cursor up/down relist, EDIT, AUTO, two-row input line, error jump	Editor test suite, Fuse screenshots	1 session
5. Polish	Size squeeze to fit the full feature list (§8.2), then the remaining §4.8 items in priority order: INPUT, DATA/READ, SAVE/VERIFY, graphics, BEEP, string functions, ERR$, CASE, EXIT, SWAP, MODE 32/UDG; a possible revisit of the 8×8 font if the margin allows, user manual (PDF, in the Mire Mare style), example tape, a check on a real TV via Nathan	`opticos.rom` v1.0, manual, examples. The repo is **OpticOS**, created only with Nathan's go-ahead.	1–2 sessions

The total is about **12–14 sessions**, which is larger than Mire Mare. Phase 1 is a useful stopping point on its own: it proves the hardware layer and tape compatibility before any BASIC exists.

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12. Decisions (agreed 13 Nov 2026)

Nathan agreed the first six recommendations on 13 November 2026; decisions 7–12 were made later the same day, and decision 13 for phase 5c.

1. **No 8×8 font at `$3D00` for now.** Ship the 4-pixel font only and get MODE 32 by pixel doubling. Revisit in Phase 5 if the margin allows. Without it, games that draw text from the ROM font show garbage.

2. **Include the legacy loader shim (about 650 bytes).** Without it, almost no commercial tape, including Bounce Ball and Mire Mare, loads with `LOAD ""`.
3. **Error handling is `TRY/CATCH/ENDTRY` plus `ERROR n`.** It is structured, it fits the no-line-number style, and it costs about the same as `ON ERROR`.
4. **Procedures are called by bare name** (`move`, not `PROC move`). They look modern, the prepass resolves them, and the cost is a small lookup on the first identifier of a statement.
5. **Superseded by decision 14 (v0.8).** ~~RST `$28` raises a clean error.~~ The Sinclair calculator is still not emulated (it would cost 600 bytes or more, and few games use it), but RST `$28` now enters OpticOS's own maths byte-code, so the clean error is gone.
6. **`LOCAL` is dynamic, in the BBC style**, not true lexical scope. Lexical scope would need per-PROC symbol tables, at about 300 bytes plus a slower lookup.
7. **No full-screen editor** (Nathan, later on 13 Nov 2026, for phase 4). Use the ZX BASIC pattern instead: a current-line marker moved with the cursor keys over a LIST, and EDIT to bring that line into the input line (§6.5).
8. **Dropped: `MODE 32` and UDG printing, `CIRCLE`** (Nathan, 13 Nov 2026, phase 5). The ROM is 64 columns only. The legacy shim prints at 64 columns and doubles `PRINT AT` columns (§3.3).
9. **Dropped: `LABEL` / `GOTO`, and there is no `GOSUB`.** PROCs replace them. Where the spec used labels, a PROC name is used instead: `RUN name` calls that PROC after the prepass; `RESTORE name` restores to the first DATA line after that DEF; `SAVE "x" AUTO name` runs that PROC after loading.
10. **Dropped: `SCREEN$(r,c)`, `ATTR`, `POINT`, `FIND`, `CONT`, `ERRLINE`, `ERRPROC$` and `SOUND`** (BEEP stays). Also, from phase 5a, `ASN` and `ACS`.
11. **The legacy loader shim stays whole**, with no trim. Bounce Ball and Mire Mare must keep loading with `LOAD ""` (the phase 1 tests check both).

12. **Both squeezes are accepted**: the remaining maths items, checked with the full 3,000-case run and the RND statistics, and shared argument parsing and RST helpers in the interpreter (§8.2).

13. **Dropped in phase 5c (Nathan, 13 Nov 2026): array parameters by reference, `CALL` register arguments, `CAT`, and the OpticBASIC `SCREEN$` tape forms** (`SCREEN$` is `CODE 16384,6912`; the legacy shim keeps `LOAD "" SCREEN$` for loaders). **`JOY` is dropped too** (read a Kempston joystick with `IN 31`). **`BORDER` stays**, in OpticBASIC and in the legacy shim, and both are tested. As built: `FREE` is a function, not a command (`PRINT FREE`); `SAVE … AUTO` and `RUN name` take a PROC without parameters; `ERROR n, msg$` keeps up to 28 characters; `EXIT` finds its WEND, UNTIL or NEXT by counting loop keywords forwards, and `EXIT FOR` drops the FOR frame, so it should not be used from inside a TRY block within the loop.

14. **Agreed (Nathan, 13 Nov 2026): RST `$28` enters the OpticOS maths byte-code** (it was "Calculator not supported", decision 5). The interpreter's 37 calls become one byte each, saving about 99 bytes with the message. Without this the ROM would have about 185 bytes free, below the 256-byte margin. Machine code that calls the Sinclair calculator fails on OpticOS either way, but it no longer stops with an error message.
15. **Agreed (Nathan, 13 Nov 2026, v0.10; halved in v0.11): larger stacks on 48K.** The workspace below RAMTOP is 4,864 bytes on a 48K machine (machine stack 2,048, control stack 2,048, value stack 512, direct line 256), up from 1,856, so recursion goes about four to five times deeper than before v0.10 (§4.8). It costs RAM, not ROM: FREE on a fresh 48K machine is 36,447 bytes (39,455 before v0.10; v0.10's 9,216-byte workspace left 32,095, and Nathan asked for the sizes to be halved). A 16K machine keeps a 2,048-byte workspace (512 / 768 / 512 / 256), because a large one would not fit. The sizes are in a 4-byte table for each RAM size (`ws_t48`, `ws_t16` in `src/vars.asm`, in 256-byte pages, so the value stack is 512, not half of 768), which CLEAR also uses for its check.

End of specification v0.13.